AUDIOBOOK ORB

Project brief & step-by-step PC guide

A quiet, cinematic companion for listening to audiobooks.

What this document is for

This document captures the concept we have agreed on and gives you a practical route to start testing the first visual prototype on your PC this morning. We will work one step at a time in chat; you do not need to understand programming before we begin.

The first goal is not to build the finished Android app. It is to make the orb look and feel right in a browser, then gradually connect it to real audiobook audio.

Project name: Audiobook Orb
Platform goal: Android, with a browser prototype first
Current stage: visual prototype planning

1. The concept we are building

Audiobook Orb is specifically an audiobook companion—not a general music visualiser, meditation app, or content-creation tool. Its purpose is to give the narrated story a subtle visual presence without demanding the listener's attention, especially at bedtime.

The central visual relationship

- The narrator is the light source. A tiny point at the exact centre emits the light and responds to the narrator's voice.
- The orb receives the light. The translucent sphere catches and refracts the emitted light across its inner and outer surfaces.
- The orb breathes independently. It slowly expands and contracts, even through short pauses in speech.
- Silence becomes black. When narration stops, the light fades out and the orb becomes completely invisible against the black background. The breathing continues invisibly underneath.
- Volume controls overall brightness. The audiobook's playback-volume setting should set the overall brightness range. The narrator's moment-to-moment dynamics and emotional tone still subtly influence the light within that range.

Visual rules

- Dark background; no permanently visible outline or residual glow during longer silences.
- Delicate, mostly horizontal anamorphic lens flares—not huge cinematic streaks.
- Soft colour shifts: deep blue for calm, muted green for warmth, and restrained red for tension. These are starting directions, not rigid rules.
- No flashing, abrupt changes, frantic pulsing, or mechanical response to every syllable.
- Controls should stay unobtrusive. A later version may reveal them with a tap or swipe around the orb rather than directly on it.
- The long-term sleep experience should fade the narration and visuals together with the audiobook's sleep timer.

Three non-negotiable rules

VOICE Creates and changes the light	BREATH The orb moves independently	SILENCE Light and orb vanish into black

2. The development plan

Stage 1 — Browser visual prototype

Make a single orb on a black screen. Test breathing, central light, subtle flares, colour changes, and disappearance into black. At first, use simple test controls or a simulated signal; do not worry about real audiobook integration yet.

Stage 2 — Tune the look and feel

Adjust the breathing speed, expansion amount, light intensity, flare subtlety, colour transitions, and silence fade until the effect feels calm rather than distracting.

Stage 3 — Test on the Android phone

Open the prototype on the phone and assess it at normal bedtime viewing distance and low screen brightness. Confirm that it feels good without needing to stare at it.

Stage 4 — Connect real audio

Investigate how to analyse audio from a supported audiobook playback source. Start with voice activity and volume dynamics; true emotional interpretation is more complex and should not be promised at the beginning.

Stage 5 — Build the Android app

Choose the app architecture and rendering approach once the prototype has proven the visual concept. Add proper controls, playback integration where technically and legally possible, and sleep-timer coordination.

Stage 6 — Ownership and release preparation

Keep dated copies of the code, designs and specifications. Check the name’s availability and use written agreements with any outside developer covering ownership of the deliverables.

A practical technical note

A browser prototype can demonstrate the visual behaviour, but it cannot automatically control every audiobook app on Android. Access to another app’s audio and synchronising with its sleep timer may have platform and app-specific limitations. We will test the visual concept first, then investigate the most practical integration route.

3. Your PC plan for this morning

We agreed to start with a browser-based prototype, because it avoids installing Android development tools before we know the visual concept works. CodePen is the first suggested workspace.

1	Open your browser On your PC, open Chrome, Edge, or another modern browser.
2	Open CodePen Type https://codepen.io/pen/ into the address bar and press Enter. This opens a new coding workspace.
3	Look for the three editors The workspace normally has panels labelled HTML, CSS, and JS (JavaScript). The preview shows the result. The layout may look different on different screen sizes.
4	Do not paste code yet Stop here and return to the Audiobook Orb chat. Tell me what you see, or send a screenshot if the page looks different. I will give you the next step based on your screen.
5	Save the work when prompted CodePen may ask you to sign in or create an account to save a Pen. Do not pay for anything just to begin. If saving is blocked, tell me and we will choose the simplest alternative.

Your only task to start

Open CodePen on your PC and tell me what you see. We will proceed one step at a time—no rushing and no giant wall of code to wrestle with.

Useful link: https://codepen.io/pen/

4. What we will test in the first prototype

- Breathing: Slow, smooth expansion and contraction; continues through short pauses and remains invisible in longer silence.
- Central source: A small, precise point at the centre. The point—not the orb surface—is the source of the emitted light.
- Anamorphic optics: Fine horizontal flare and delicate reflections that catch on the orb. Keep them restrained and mostly hidden.
- Narration response: Initially use a test signal or controls to tune the response. Later, test real voice activity and dynamics.
- Volume-to-brightness: A lower playback volume should correspond to a dimmer overall effect; a higher volume can allow a brighter effect without becoming harsh.
- Silence: After a gentle fade, no visible dot, edge, glow, or reflections remain against the black background.
- Sleep comfort: No flashing, abrupt changes, or bright bursts. The visual should be calm enough to leave in peripheral vision.

A note about narrator emotion

Colour responding to emotion is part of the vision, but a prototype should not pretend that simple loudness detection understands emotion. We can first create gentle, controllable colour behaviour, then assess what real-time audio analysis can reliably support.

Protecting the work

- Save dated versions of the written specification, source code, screenshots, and original visual designs.
- Copyright generally protects qualifying original expression—such as original code and artwork—not the broad idea of a breathing orb responding to narration.
- Before a commercial release, check whether “Audiobook Orb” is available for the relevant software and services, and get professional IP advice if needed.

The product test

The question for the first prototype is simple: does the light seem to reveal a breathing presence in the darkness, without pulling attention away from the audiobook?

Project status: concept defined; browser prototype not yet built. Next action: open CodePen on the PC and continue in chat.